

Improving Room Readiness Through Better Team Coordination

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Company Access

Our team secured access to the Finance Department at the Hilton New York Times Square, along with additional access to employees in the front office, housekeeping, and operations. Our primary contact, Stephanie Dontis, a member of the Finance Department, facilitated connections with both managerial and frontline employees, allowing us to gather perspectives across multiple levels of the organization. This access was critical in enabling a more comprehensive understanding of both strategic decision-making and day-to-day operational challenges within the hotel. It also allowed us to compare how different departments experience and respond to peak occupancy conditions, providing a more well-rounded view of the organization.

The Hilton brand was founded in Cisco, Texas, by Conrad Hilton in 1919 and has since grown into a global leader in hospitality, known for innovations such as airport hotels and in-room televisions. The Hilton New York Times Square property, which opened in 2000, is a 44-story hotel offering modern accommodations in a high-demand, high-visibility location. With approximately 150 employees, the hotel operates in an environment driven by tourism cycles, seasonal fluctuations, and large group bookings. Due to its location in Times Square, the property must consistently deliver efficient service despite frequent spikes in occupancy, making effective coordination across departments essential to maintaining operational performance.

In addition to interviews, our level of access allowed us to gather insights into internal processes such as communication practices, staffing approaches, and performance tracking methods.

Output Problem

Based on our initial interview with Mrs. Dontis and subsequent interviews with both managers and employees, our team identified the primary output problem as delays in room readiness during peak occupancy periods. These delays directly impact check-in efficiency and overall

guest experience, often resulting in longer wait times and increased pressure on front desk staff. While “operational efficiency” was initially identified as a broad concern, further investigation allowed us to pinpoint a more specific internal bottleneck: inconsistent communication and coordination between the front desk and housekeeping regarding room status and prioritization. This bottleneck becomes most visible during high-demand periods, when even small delays or miscommunications can significantly disrupt workflow.

The hotel operates in a high-volume, high-variability environment, requiring constant coordination between departments. Time-sensitive room turnover demands, particularly ensuring that rooms are ready by standard check-in times, increase pressure during peak periods. At the same time, management must balance strong guest service standards with labor efficiency targets, making staffing and scheduling alignment critical. When communication timing, forecasting accuracy, or workload distribution is slightly misaligned, inefficiencies become more pronounced. From a managerial perspective, the problem is often described using measurable indicators such as labor utilization, overtime, and forecasting accuracy, while frontline employees describe it in terms of workload intensity, communication challenges, and stress during busy shifts. Although these perspectives differ in framing, both point to the same root issue: gaps in cross-department coordination that limit the hotel’s ability to maintain consistent efficiency during peak periods.

Data Collection Methods

To investigate and quantify the output problem, our team implemented a structured data collection approach that combined both qualitative and quantitative methods, following a clearly defined timeline. In the initial phase (Weeks 3–4), we focused on problem scoping by confirming the issue with our primary contact, identifying key departments involved, and developing

interview questions tailored to both managerial and frontline perspectives. During Weeks 5–6, we conducted semi-structured interviews with managers across finance and operations, focusing on operational metrics such as forecasting accuracy, labor utilization, and coordination challenges. This was followed in Week 7 by interviews with frontline employees in the front desk and housekeeping departments to better understand real-time workflow disruptions, communication gaps, and workload pressures during peak occupancy periods. This staged approach allowed us to first understand the problem at a strategic level and then validate it through employee experiences, ultimately helping us identify the specific bottleneck related to communication and room readiness.

In Weeks 8–9, we collected quantitative data through a structured survey and available operational metrics. The survey used a 1–5 Likert scale to measure employee perceptions of workload, communication effectiveness, coordination, and service efficiency, and was distributed to approximately 15–20 employees across departments to identify consistent patterns. The questions were designed based on recurring themes from the interviews to ensure alignment between qualitative and quantitative findings. At the same time, we reviewed internal performance indicators where available, including room readiness rates, overtime trends, and guest satisfaction data, to support and validate our findings. In Week 10, we analyzed both qualitative and quantitative data to identify trends, compare responses across departments, and connect findings to course concepts. Additionally, triangulating data from interviews, surveys, and internal metrics increased the reliability of our conclusions by confirming patterns across multiple sources. This phased and multi-method approach ensured a comprehensive understanding of the problem and strengthened our ability to draw accurate, data-driven conclusions about the causes of operational inefficiencies.

Summary of Interview Data

The interview data indicates that the primary operational issue is inefficiency in room readiness, which directly impacts check-in flow and overall guest satisfaction. This problem was consistently identified across both managerial and frontline perspectives, although each group emphasized different aspects of the issue. Interviews were conducted with Stephanie (Assistant Director of Finance), Linda (Director of Finance), and Ashley (Director of Operations), as well as frontline employees Stephanie and George (Guest Service Agents) and Blanca (housekeeping). Managers primarily highlighted coordination and system-level challenges. Stephanie and Linda explained that while finance operates with structured processes, breakdowns occur when other departments do not communicate updates effectively, impacting forecasting and overall coordination. Ashley further emphasized operational bottlenecks during peak occupancy, including front desk congestion, housekeeping delays, and resource constraints such as staffing shortages and linen availability.

Frontline employees described the issue in more immediate, operational terms. Stephanie and George, working at the front desk, emphasized long guest wait times, constant interruptions, and the need to repeatedly confirm room status with housekeeping, all of which slow down the check-in process. Blanca, representing housekeeping, highlighted the heavy workload, strict time constraints, and frequent priority changes that reduce efficiency and delay room turnover. A consistent theme across all interviews is a breakdown in communication between departments, particularly between the front desk and housekeeping. Delayed or unclear updates on room status, combined with inconsistent shift handoffs, contribute significantly to inefficiencies. While factors such as staffing shortages, late checkouts, and supply delays also play a role, the findings

suggest that these challenges are intensified by weak coordination. Overall, the core issue is not simply high demand, but a lack of alignment and integration across interdependent roles.

Taken together, these findings demonstrate that the output problem is systemic rather than isolated to a single department. Both managerial insights and frontline experiences point to the same underlying issue: coordination breakdowns that disrupt workflow during peak periods. The consistency of this theme across all interviews strengthens the conclusion that improving communication and integration between departments, particularly between the front desk and housekeeping, will be critical to improving room readiness and overall operational efficiency.

Identification of Course Concept

The course concept selected to analyze the output problem is Building Effective Teams, which emphasizes key elements such as team composition, mutual accountability, communication, and coordination. This concept is especially relevant because the interviews revealed that, although all departments are working toward the shared goal of guest satisfaction, they often operate independently rather than as a cohesive unit. As a result, breakdowns in communication and coordination directly contribute to delays in room readiness and inefficiencies in the check-in process. In a high-pressure, high-occupancy environment like this hotel, effective teamwork is not just beneficial but essential, as tasks across departments are highly interdependent and time-sensitive.

Evidence from the interviews strongly supports the application of this concept. Stephanie from finance explained that “employees often prioritize their own department’s tasks, which can create tension when other departments need assistance,” indicating limited mutual accountability across teams. Similarly, Ashley, Director of Operations, noted that “departments can become siloed, so leadership involvement in daily operations could improve coordination and service delivery,”

highlighting a lack of integration. Linda from finance also emphasized communication gaps between shifts, noting that important information does not always carry over, particularly between housekeeping and the front office. This is reinforced by frontline employees, who described how high-pressure conditions leave little time to coordinate effectively between tasks, especially during peak occupancy periods. These insights point to a lack of structured coordination time and standardized processes, such as shift handoffs, which are critical for building trust and shared understanding across teams.

Applying the Building Effective Teams concept provides a framework for addressing the root cause of the problem by shifting the organization from a collection of independent groups to a more integrated, team-based structure. This includes strengthening communication channels, clarifying interdependent roles, and fostering shared accountability for outcomes such as room readiness and guest satisfaction. Additionally, it highlights the importance of creating systems that support coordination in real time, rather than relying on reactive communication. By implementing these principles, the hotel can improve alignment across departments, reduce inefficiencies, and create a more consistent and effective operational flow during peak periods.

Method for Quantifying the Output Problem

To quantify the output problem in a structured and objective way, the team used a survey-based approach to convert qualitative interview findings into measurable data. The survey targeted approximately 20 participants across key departments, including the front desk, housekeeping, operations, and finance, and included 15 questions using a 1–5 scale (1 = strongly disagree, 5 = strongly agree). The questions were designed to directly reflect the key issues identified in the interviews, including room readiness performance, interdepartmental communication, staffing adequacy, workload management, and overall operational efficiency. By aligning survey

questions with interview themes, the team ensured that the data collected would specifically measure the severity of the identified bottlenecks rather than general perceptions.

To analyze the results, the team calculated average scores for each survey item to determine overall levels of agreement and identify areas of operational weakness. Composite scores were created by grouping related questions into categories such as communication, staffing, room readiness, and coordination, allowing for clearer identification of the most significant problem areas. In addition, a top-box analysis was used to measure the percentage of responses rated 4 or 5, providing insight into how widespread specific challenges are across employees. Responses were also compared across roles and departments to highlight differences in perception between managers and frontline staff, as well as between front desk and housekeeping employees.

Further analysis included identifying gaps between categories—for example, comparing high ratings in workload demands with lower ratings in communication effectiveness—to better understand where operational strain is not being adequately supported. This allowed the team to quantify not only the presence of the problem but also its underlying drivers. By combining these analytical approaches, the survey results provided a clear, data-driven picture of the severity of the output problem and the specific areas contributing to inefficiency. This method is effective because it transforms subjective employee experiences into standardized, comparable data, enabling the team to prioritize targeted improvements in communication, staffing, and cross-department coordination.

Quantifying and Contextualizing the Output Problem

The survey results give clear numbers that show how severe the output problem is, especially when it comes to workload, delays, and communication during busy times. Respondents gave a very high score of about 4.5 out of 5 to the idea that busy times mean more work, which shows

that they strongly agree that peak occupancy makes job responsibilities much harder. Delays in operations, like room readiness, check-in, and service requests, also averaged around 4.5, which shows that departments consistently have problems with efficiency. On the other hand, ratings for communication-related factors, such as how clear things are between departments and how quickly updates are sent out, were much lower, averaging around 3.3–3.4. This means that employees see operational pressure as a big problem, but they don't think that communication systems are just as helpful during these times.

The difference between these averages, which is about 1.0 to 1.3 points on a 5-point scale, is important because it shows a big gap between what the organization needs to do and what it can do to help. In real life, this means that employees are often under a lot of stress without the right level of coordination to handle it well. Also, more than 80% of people who answered said that workload demands and delays were a 4 or 5, showing that there is a strong agreement that these problems are common and not limited to certain roles or departments. On the other hand, less than half of the people who answered said that communication and coordination were at the same level, which shows that departments don't always work well together. This gap shows that better communication could have a direct and measurable effect on speeding up work and cutting down on delays. The data shows that the output problem is not only bad, but also a systemic one.

Weak communication makes the effects of already high operational demands even worse.

To further evaluate how these values fall short, it is important to compare them to what the organization should ideally achieve. In a highly efficient service organization, especially in the hospitality industry where tasks are closely interconnected, communication and coordination should be just as strong as workload performance. Ideally, communication-related ratings would fall in the range of about 4.2 to 4.5 out of 5, showing that employees feel consistently informed

and supported even during peak times. However, the current communication scores of 3.3–3.4 fall noticeably below this range, representing a gap of nearly one full point. On a 5-point scale, this is a meaningful difference and suggests that communication systems are not keeping up with operational demands.

This gap is also supported by employee perceptions from both surveys and interviews. Many employees indicated that better communication and coordination would make a clear difference in how effectively they can do their jobs. Survey responses showed that overall effectiveness could improve to around 4.3 out of 5 if communication were stronger. Compared to the current communication ratings, this shows that the organization is falling short not only of an ideal benchmark, but also of what employees themselves believe is realistic and achievable.

The interview data gives more context to why this gap exists. Employees across departments described situations where they had to repeatedly follow up for updates, especially when it came to room for readiness. Front desk employees mentioned having to contact housekeeping multiple times while guests were waiting, which slows down the check-in process and increases stress. At the same time, housekeeping staff explained that changing priorities throughout the shift and unclear communication about which rooms to focus on can interrupt their workflow and reduce efficiency. Managers also pointed out that communication breakdowns between shifts can cause important information to be missed, which leads to delays and confusion. These examples show that the lower communication scores are not just perceptions but are directly tied to real operational inefficiencies.

Overall, while workload and operational pressure are consistently rated very high (around 4.5), the systems in place to support that workload are not at the same level. This imbalance shows that the organization is not operating as efficiently as it could be. The gap between workload

demands and communication effectiveness is clear, measurable, and widely experienced across departments. Because of this, the severity of the output problem is significant, and improving communication would likely have a direct impact on reducing delays, improving coordination, and making operations run more smoothly during busy periods.

Recommendation

To address inefficiencies in room readiness and interdepartmental coordination, we recommend implementing a simple, real-time communication system between housekeeping and the front desk. This could take the form of a shared digital platform, such as a live dashboard or a continuously updated Google Sheet, where housekeeping staff update room status immediately upon completion, and front desk staff can view this information in real time. This solution is intentionally low-cost and easy to implement, while directly targeting the communication bottleneck identified through both interview and survey data. By reducing delays in information transfer, this system would improve the speed and accuracy of the check-in process.

This recommendation is grounded in the distinction between groups and teams. Currently, the front desk and housekeeping function largely as independent groups, communicating reactively rather than collaboratively. Information is often exchanged only when needed, leading to repeated follow-ups and inefficiencies. A shared, real-time communication system would enable these departments to operate more as an integrated team, fostering mutual awareness and interdependence in achieving the shared goal of efficient guest service. This shift from a group-based structure to a team-based approach would reduce miscommunication and streamline workflow. According to the Harvard Business Review, effective teams rely on real-time communication and coordination to perform interdependent tasks efficiently (Edmondson, 2012).

Interview and survey data further support this recommendation. Employees across departments consistently identified delays in receiving and sharing information, particularly regarding room readiness, as a major challenge during high-occupancy periods. Survey results showed that communication clarity averaged approximately 3.33, and timely updates averaged around 3.42, both lower than other operational areas. While these differences may appear modest, they are significant in the context of a 5-point scale. Notably, respondents indicated strong agreement (approximately 4.33) that improved coordination would enhance their ability to perform effectively. This demonstrates that the issue is not only workload-related but also rooted in how information flows between departments. Implementing a real-time system would address both concerns by minimizing repeated status checks and reducing uncertainty around room availability.

Supporting research further reinforces the effectiveness of this approach. Studies have shown that employees working in interdependent roles who communicate consistently achieve higher levels of performance and efficiency (Gittell, 2003). Similar findings within the hospitality industry indicate that improved information sharing across departments leads to higher guest satisfaction. Additionally, organizations that implement real-time communication systems are better equipped to manage workflow disruptions and reduce service delays (O'Neill & Mattila, 2006). These findings demonstrate that strengthening communication systems is a well-established and effective strategy for addressing coordination-related inefficiencies.

Overall, implementing a real-time room status communication system would transform the relationship between departments from loosely connected groups into a coordinated team. By improving information flow, reducing redundant communication, and aligning both departments

around a shared objective, this recommendation directly addresses the root cause of the output problem while remaining practical, scalable, and cost-effective.

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